

Recruiters, applications, take-homes, on-sites

Week 9, Lecture 1 · Landing the Offer: SWE Job Search for Senior CS Students

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Cold messages that get recruiter replies
- The referral path: asking for a real referral, not a name drop
- Application cadence: how many, when, and the October cliff
- Take-homes: deciding when the time investment is worth it
- On-site logistics: what to do before, during, and after the loop
- The follow-up that strengthens the close

Part 1: reaching recruiters

Most cold outreach fails in the first sentence

- Recruiters at large tech companies read hundreds of InMails per week
- The ones they respond to name a specific role, show preparation, and give the recruiter one clear action in the first two sentences
- Generic messages ("I'm interested in opportunities at your company") get archived without a reply
- The goal is not to impress them; the goal is to make their job easier

Orosz and Stockman (2025): "Recruiters read hundreds of InMails a week. The ones they respond to are specific about the role, show they've done their homework, and give the recruiter something to act on in the first two sentences."

A cold message that works

Two-sentence structure:

1. Name the role and one specific reason you fit it (a project, a skill, a publication the team would recognize)
2. Ask for one concrete action: a 20-minute call, a referral to the right hiring manager, or confirmation that applications are open

What to leave out: your GPA, how much you admire the company, and anything that requires the recruiter to do research on your behalf before they have decided to reply.

The referral path: two versions

Weak referral

- "Hey, you should apply, here's the link"
- No written endorsement
- No portal submission
- Does not accelerate recruiter review
- Often indistinguishable from a cold application

Strong referral

- Contact submits your resume through the internal portal
- Adds a written note about why you are a good fit
- Flags the recruiter directly by name

How to ask for the strong referral

Key constraints:

- Your contact has limited social capital with the recruiter; spend it on a specific ask, not a vague endorsement
- Give your contact everything they need to write the submission in under five minutes: your resume, the exact role URL, and three bullet points about your fit
- Make it easy for them to say yes and easy for them to say no

The ask: "Would you be willing to submit my resume through the internal portal for the [role name] posting? I have already applied directly, but I know an internal submission gets different routing. I can send you my resume and the exact URL right now."

Part 2: application cadence

The recruiting calendar has hard edges

- Most new-grad full-time applications open in August and September for the following summer or fall start
- On-sites cluster in October through December; offers go out November through January
- Many offer deadlines fall before you have heard back from other companies
- Starting late in November means competing for the remaining seats after the main hiring cycle has run

Tay (Tech Interview Handbook, 2023): the window is real. Candidates who apply in late October are often filling the positions that early-October candidates turned down.

How many applications per week

A calibrated approach:

- 5-10 active applications per week during the core window (August through October)
- Not more, because each application that reaches on-site requires real preparation time
- Not fewer, because you need a pipeline wide enough to produce simultaneous competing offers
- Target: at least 2-3 active conversations at any given moment in September and October

The goal is simultaneous offers, not sequential ones. Sequential offers give you no leverage.

Rejection pipeline management

Rejections are data:

- A rejection at the resume screen tells you something about keyword gaps or application timing
- A rejection after the phone screen tells you something about recruiter fit or your cold pitch
- A rejection after the on-site tells you about your interview performance, not your worth as an engineer
- Track every rejection with a stage and a hypothesis about why; revisit the hypothesis if the pattern repeats

Tay (2023): most candidates treat rejections as noise. Treating them as signal is a competitive advantage.

Part 3: take-homes and on-sites

Deciding whether to do a take-home

A take-home is worth doing when:

- The company is in your top 10 and the role is a genuine match
- The estimated time (ask for a realistic estimate if none is given) fits your week
- The problem is scoped: a clear deliverable, a defined evaluation rubric, and an explicit reviewer team

Decline (politely) when:

- The estimated time exceeds 6-8 hours and the company is a safety-tier application
- The problem is so open-ended that it signals organizational dysfunction
- You are already at on-site stage with two higher-priority companies this week

On-site logistics: the three days that matter

Before the on-site:

- Confirm the schedule in writing: round count, format, order, interviewer names if available
- Ask the recruiter for a prep brief: what should you know about the process
- Do one timed practice session per interview type the day before; no all-nighters

During the on-site:

- Treat every round as independent; a bad round does not determine the outcome
- Ask clarifying questions before writing code or sketching a design
- Name your assumptions out loud

After the on-site:

- Send a follow-up the same day

The follow-up that adds something

What the follow-up should contain:

1. One sentence of genuine, specific appreciation (name a question or a problem that was interesting)
2. One additional thought or clarification from a round where you wish you had said something different
3. A clear statement of continued interest, without neediness

What to avoid: restating your resume, making up experience you do not have, and asking for a timeline in a way that implies you are nervous rather than organized.

Subject: "Following up after today" is fine. Long subject lines get truncated.

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Take-aways

1. Cold messages succeed when they name a specific role, show preparation, and give the recruiter one clear action in the first two sentences.
2. A strong referral means a portal submission with a written endorsement, not a verbal mention. Ask for it explicitly and make it easy to give.
3. Apply 5-10 active applications per week during August through October. Sequential offers give you no negotiating leverage.
4. Decline take-homes that do not fit your week or your tier ranking. Accepting every take-home drains time from higher-priority pipelines.
5. The post-on-site follow-up should add one new thought and state genuine interest without summarizing what the interviewer already saw.

What's next

- **Reading (this week):** week 9 reading covers total compensation math, leveling, and negotiation scripts; read before Lecture 2
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** negotiation, leveling, and multi-offer dynamics
- **Section (this week):** live pipeline triage with peer review, then negotiation role-play in pairs
- **HW 5 (due this week):** STAR story bank of 12 stories; make sure your stories cover the leadership principles you mapped in week 7